

Elliptic Curves Over Finite Fields and Applications to Cryptography

2026 School on Arithmetic, Geometry and Algorithms

Juanita Duque-Rosero

Bernoulli Institute, University of Groningen.

j.duque.rosero@rug.nl

Introduction

These lecture notes accompany the lectures for the course on elliptic curves over finite fields and applications to cryptography for the 2026 School on Arithmetic, Geometry and Algorithms. The main references I used are [Kun26, Sil09]. Other useful references are [HPS14, AM26].

At the heart of public-key cryptography are functions that are easy to compute but are believed hard to reverse without secret information. In these notes, we first build the arithmetic of elliptic curves over finite fields from explicit formulas. We then use it to formulate the discrete logarithm problem and elliptic-curve Diffie–Hellman. At the end, we will discuss isogenies and their cryptographic context.

These notes were prepared with the help of ChatGPT 5.6 Terra. All errors are my own.

Explicit computations

The ideal way to follow these notes is to try examples in your favorite computer algebra system. I recommend you use the open source software [SageMath](#), but you are welcome to use whatever you prefer ([Magma](#), [Oscar](#), [PARI/GP](#), etc.).

Prerequisites

The required background includes arithmetic in $\mathbb{F}_p$: modular addition, multiplication, inverses, and polynomial evaluation. Basic group theory is also used in the course.

A note from the author

Despite my best efforts, these notes may contain typos. If you spot any, please feel free to email me; I appreciate your help!

Acknowledgments

These notes were inspired by the Arizona Winter School 2026: Computational Aspects of Arithmetic Geometry and Cryptography, and the Preliminary Arizona Winter School 2025: Mathematical cryptography and algorithms in number theory. Thank you to the speakers, Sarah Arpin, Kirsten Eisentraeger, David Harvey, Sabrina Kunzweiler, Chloe Martindale, and John Voight and to the organizers Renee Bell, Daniel Erman, Brandon Levin, Anna Medvedovsky, Padma Srinivasan, Anthony Várilly-Alvarado, Isabel Vogt, and Hang Xue.

Contents

1	Elliptic curves over finite fields	1
1.1	A short toolkit	1
1.1.1	Arithmetic in $\mathbb{F}_p$	1
1.2	Curves and their points	2
1.2.1	Points on elliptic curves	3
1.2.2	Counting points by hand	4
1.3	The group law	5
1.4	How many points can there be?	7
1.5	Practice problems	7
2	The elliptic-curve discrete logarithm problem	9
2.1	Public-key cryptography	9
2.2	Further structure of the points on elliptic curves	10
2.3	The discrete logarithm problem	11
2.4	What is assumed to be hard?	11
2.5	Diffie–Hellman key agreement	12

Lecture 1: Elliptic curves over finite fields

This course starts with arithmetic in prime fields. Our immediate goal is to construct a finite abelian group from a polynomial equation and learn to compute in it. The cryptographic applications in later lectures use exactly this arithmetic, but with primes and subgroup orders too large to enumerate.

Throughout this lecture, $p > 3$ is a prime.

1.1 A short toolkit

1.1.1 Arithmetic in $\mathbb{F}_p$

The elements of $\mathbb{F}_p$ are $0, 1, \dots, p-1$, with addition and multiplication reduced modulo p . Every nonzero element $a \in \mathbb{F}_p$ has a unique inverse a^{-1} , so division by a means multiplication by a^{-1} . For example, in $\mathbb{F}_7$ we have $2^{-1} = 4$, since $2 \cdot 4 = 8 = 1$.

Definition 1.1. An element $r \in \mathbb{F}_p$ is a **quadratic residue** if $r = y^2$ for some $y \in \mathbb{F}_p$. Otherwise it is a **quadratic nonresidue**.

For p odd, every nonzero quadratic residue has exactly two square roots, y and $-y$, while 0 has one. Thus a table of squares is enough to count points on the curves in this lecture.

Example 1.2. The squares in $\mathbb{F}_7$ are

$$0^2 = 0, \quad 1^2 = 6^2 = 1, \quad 2^2 = 5^2 = 4, \quad 3^2 = 4^2 = 2.$$

Hence the quadratic residues in $\mathbb{F}_7$ are 0, 1, 2, 4.

 **Exercise 1.3.** In this problem, you will study quadratic residues in finite fields.

1. Find the quadratic residues in $\mathbb{F}_{11}$ and $\mathbb{F}_{13}$. How many are there in each case?
2. Can you find a pattern in the number of quadratic residues in $\mathbb{F}_p$ for odd primes p ?
3. Can you prove the formula you found? *Hint: consider the map $x \mapsto x^2$ on the nonzero elements of $\mathbb{F}_p$.*

1.2 Curves and their points

An elliptic curve over a field k is a geometric object described here by an equation in two variables. In this course we use the **short Weierstrass equation**

$$y^2 = x^3 + ax + b,$$

where a and b are chosen constants in k . Usually, k will denote the finite fields $\mathbb{F}_p$ or $\mathbb{F}_{p^2}$. A solution $(x, y) \in k^2$ is called an **affine point** of the curve, or simply a point of the curve.

For example, on $y^2 = x^3 + x + 1$ over $\mathbb{F}_7$, taking $x = 2$ gives

$$y^2 = 2^3 + 2 + 1 = 4.$$

In 1.2, we saw that 4 is a quadratic residue in $\mathbb{F}_7$, so there are two values of y that satisfy the equation. Since $2^2 = 4$ and $5^2 = 4$ in $\mathbb{F}_7$, this value $x = 2$ gives the two affine points $(2, 2)$ and $(2, 5)$. For a fixed x , there can similarly be zero, one, or two affine points, according as the right-hand side is a nonresidue, zero, or a nonzero quadratic residue.

Finally, not every equation of this shape gives an elliptic curve. We require that it have no singular point—no crossing or cusp in its geometric picture. For a short Weierstrass equation in characteristic different from 2 and 3, this is exactly the nonvanishing condition in the following definition. It is what makes the addition law well behaved.

Definition 1.4. Recall that $p > 3$. An elliptic curve in short Weierstrass form over $\mathbb{F}_p$ is an equation

$$E: y^2 = x^3 + ax + b, \quad a, b \in \mathbb{F}_p, \quad (1.5)$$

such that

$$4a^3 + 27b^2 \neq 0.$$

Its set of $\mathbb{F}_p$ -points is

$$E(\mathbb{F}_p) = \{(x, y) \in \mathbb{F}_p^2 : y^2 = x^3 + ax + b\} \cup \{O\}.$$

The extra symbol O , called the **point at infinity**, will be the identity element of the group law.

To see where O comes from, homogenize the equation:

$$Y^2Z = X^3 + aXZ^2 + bZ^3.$$

In projective coordinates the solutions with $Z = 0$ consist of the single point $[0 : 1 : 0]$, represented in the affine formulas by O . Including this point is what allows point addition to have an identity.

Remark 1.6. The restriction $p > 3$ is deliberate: it makes this short equation and the formulas below valid without exceptional characteristic-2 or characteristic-3 cases.

 **Exercise 1.7.** Graph the real solutions of $y^2 = f(x)$ for

$$f(x) = x^3 - 1, \quad f(x) = x^3 - x, \quad f(x) = x^3 - x^2.$$

Which of these equations are nonsingular and hence define elliptic curves over $\mathbb{R}$?

Definition 1.8. The discriminant of (1.5) is

$$\Delta(E) = -16(4a^3 + 27b^2).$$

The condition $\Delta(E) \neq 0$ says that the cubic on the right has no repeated root. In this case, we say that E is **nonsingular**. If $\Delta(E) = 0$, then E is **singular** and has a cusp or crossing point.

 **Exercise 1.9.** For which primes $p > 3$ does $y^2 = x^3 + x + 2$ fail to define an elliptic curve over $\mathbb{F}_p$? What about over $\mathbb{F}_{p^2}$?

 **Exercise 1.10.** Let k be a field of characteristic different from 2 and 3, and let $f(x) = x^3 + ax + b$.

1. Show that $4a^3 + 27b^2 = 0$ if and only if f has a repeated root.
2. Use the partial derivatives of $g(x, y) = y^2 - x^3 - ax - b$ to show that f having a repeated root is equivalent to the existence of a singular affine point on the curve.

1.2.1 Points on elliptic curves

The same equation can be studied over any field containing its coefficients.

Definition 1.11. Let k and K be fields with $k \subseteq K$ and k being a subfield of K . Then we say that K is an **extension field** of k . We denote this by K/k .

If E is defined over k and K/k is a field extension, then

$$E(K) := \{(x, y) \in K^2 : y^2 = x^3 + ax + b\} \cup \{O\}.$$

The notation $\#E(K)$ denotes the number of these points when the set is finite.

Example 1.12 (One curve over several fields). Consider the nonsingular short Weierstrass equation

$$E: y^2 = x^3 - 27x + 2970,$$

Over $\mathbb{C}$, every value of x except a root of the cubic gives two values of y , so $E(\mathbb{C})$ is infinite. Over $\mathbb{R}$,

$$x^3 - 27x + 2970 = (x + 15)(x^2 - 15x + 198),$$

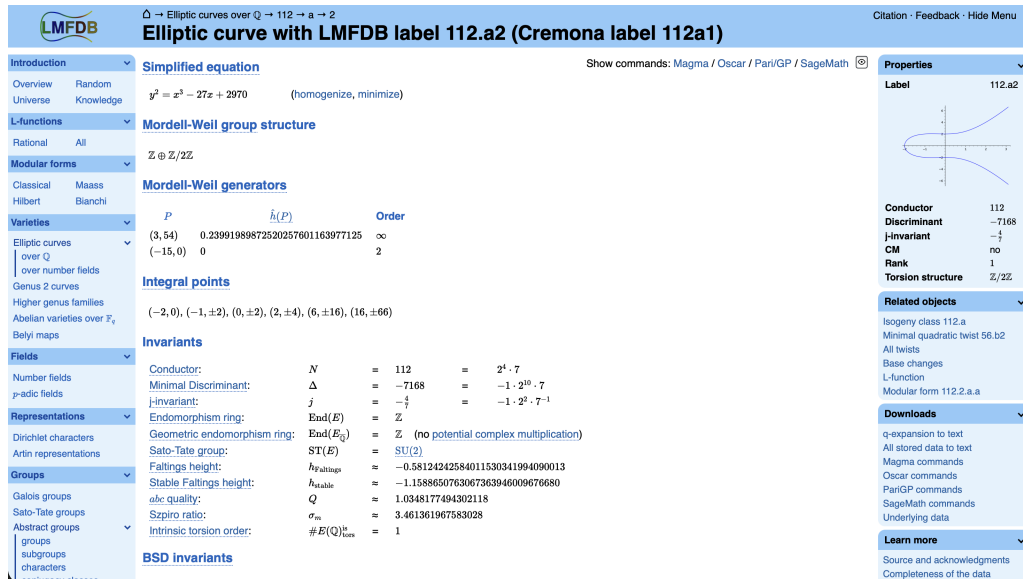
and $x^2 - 15x + 198 > 0$ for every real x . Thus $E(\mathbb{R})$ has affine points exactly when $x \geq -15$, including $(-15, 0)$. Over $\mathbb{Q}$, the points $(-15, 0)$, $(3, \pm 54)$, and $(21, \pm 108)$ are rational.

Over $\mathbb{F}_{11}$, direct enumeration gives

$$E(\mathbb{F}_{11}) = \{O, (0, 0), (2, \pm 3), (3, \pm 1), (4, 0), (5, \pm 1), (7, 0), (10, \pm 2)\},$$

so $\#E(\mathbb{F}_{11}) = 12$. Over the quadratic extension $\mathbb{F}_{11^2}$ the same curve has 144 points. The points over $\mathbb{F}_{11}$ are included among these extension-field points. Questions about integral points, obtained by asking for integer coordinates rather than field-valued coordinates, lead to deeper arithmetic geometry; see [Zag87].

A useful source for further examples and arithmetic data is the [LMFDB elliptic-curve database](#). The page for the curve in Example 1.12 is [this](#). It contains a wealth of information, including the number of points over many finite fields, the group structure of $E(\mathbb{F}_p)$ for many primes p , and the torsion subgroup over $\mathbb{Q}$.



Exercise 1.13. For each curve below, compute $\#E(\mathbb{F}_5)$. Then use SageMath to compute $\#E(\mathbb{F}_{5^2})$. Do you see a pattern?

$$y^2 = x^3 - x, \quad y^2 = x^3 + x + 1.$$

1.2.2 Counting points by hand

For each $x \in \mathbb{F}_p$, compute $x^3 + ax + b$ and look it up in the table of quadratic residues. A nonzero residue gives two points, 0 gives one, and a nonresidue gives none. Finally add O .

Example 1.14. Let $E/\mathbb{F}_7$ be

$$E: y^2 = x^3 + x + 1.$$

The values of $x^3 + x + 1$ for $x = 0, 1, \dots, 6$ are

$$1, 3, 4, 3, 6, 5, 6.$$

Only 1 and 4 are quadratic residues in this list. Therefore

$$E(\mathbb{F}_7) = \{O, (0, 1), (0, 6), (2, 2), (2, 5)\}, \quad \#E(\mathbb{F}_7) = 5.$$

 **Exercise 1.15.** Count the points on each curve over $\mathbb{F}_7$:

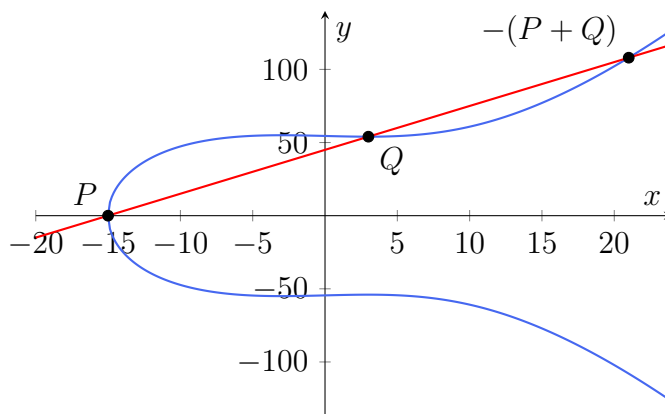
$$y^2 = x^3 - x, \quad y^2 = x^3 + 3.$$

Check that their point counts are 8 and 13, respectively.

1.3 The group law

Over the real numbers one can picture the group law by drawing a line through two points, finding the third intersection, and reflecting in the x -axis. Over $\mathbb{F}_p$ there is no picture, but the same algebraic formulas work using modular inverses.

Equivalently, three collinear points on a nonsingular cubic add to O (with intersection multiplicities counted). For the real curve in Example 1.12, the line through $P = (-15, 0)$ and $Q = (3, 54)$ also meets the curve at $R = (21, 108)$. Thus $P + Q + R = O$, and $P + Q = (21, -108)$.



Theorem 1.16 (Addition formulas). *Let $E : y^2 = x^3 + ax + b$ be an elliptic curve over $\mathbb{F}_p$.*

1. *O is the identity: $P + O = O + P = P$.*
2. *The inverse of (x, y) is $-(x, y) = (x, -y)$.*
3. *If $P = (x_1, y_1)$ and $Q = (x_2, y_2)$ with $x_1 \neq x_2$, put*

$$m = \frac{y_2 - y_1}{x_2 - x_1}, \quad x_3 = m^2 - x_1 - x_2, \quad y_3 = m(x_1 - x_3) - y_1.$$

Then $P + Q = (x_3, y_3)$.

4. *If $P = (x_1, y_1)$ with $y_1 \neq 0$, put*

$$m = \frac{3x_1^2 + a}{2y_1}, \quad x_3 = m^2 - 2x_1, \quad y_3 = m(x_1 - x_3) - y_1.$$

Then $[2]P = (x_3, y_3)$.

5. *If $Q = -P$, including the case $y_1 = y_2 = 0$, then $P + Q = O$.*

With these rules, $(E(\mathbb{F}_p), +)$ is a finite abelian group.

The associativity assertion is the hard part of this theorem; it follows from the projective geometry of a nonsingular cubic. A proof of the group law and the formulas appears in [Sil09, Ch. III, §§2–3]. We will use the theorem, not attempt that proof here.

Example 1.17. Continue with Example 1.14. For $P = (0, 1)$, doubling gives

$$m = \frac{1}{2} = 4 \pmod{7}, \quad [2]P = (2, 5).$$

Adding P to $(2, 5)$ gives $[3]P = (2, 2)$, then $[4]P = (0, 6)$, and finally $[5]P = O$. Thus P generates all of $E(\mathbb{F}_7)$.

Definition 1.18. The scalar multiplication $[n]P$ is computed efficiently by **double-and-add**: write n in binary, repeatedly double the current point, and add only at the binary digits equal to 1. This needs only about $\log_2 n$ doublings and additions.

 **Exercise 1.19.** Use double-and-add to compute $[13]P$ for $P = (0, 1)$ on the curve in Example 1.14. Explain why the answer could also have been found by reducing 13 modulo $\text{ord}(P)$.

Remark 1.20. If instead of $\mathbb{F}_p$ we work over the rational numbers $\mathbb{Q}$, then the group $E(\mathbb{Q})$ is finitely generated by Mordell-Weil's theorem. The torsion subgroup is classified by Mazur's theorem, and the rank of the free part is still the subject of current research. It is not even known whether the rank can be arbitrarily large. You can find a list of the largest known ranks at [this link](#).

1.4 How many points can there be?

The elementary bound $\#E(\mathbb{F}_q) \leq 2q + 1$ follows by counting the at most two y -values above each x . Hasse's theorem is vastly sharper; see [Sil09, Ch. V, §1].

Theorem 1.21 (Hasse). *If E is an elliptic curve over $\mathbb{F}_q$, then*

$$q + 1 - 2\sqrt{q} \leq \#E(\mathbb{F}_q) \leq q + 1 + 2\sqrt{q}.$$

For $q = 7$, the possible integer values lie between 3 and 13. This explains why the examples above can have dramatically different point counts, even though both are defined over the same field.

Example 1.22. The two ends of Hasse's interval already occur over $\mathbb{F}_7$:

$$E_1 : y^2 = x^3 - 3 \quad \text{has } \#E_1(\mathbb{F}_7) = 3, \quad E_2 : y^2 = x^3 + 3 \quad \text{has } \#E_2(\mathbb{F}_7) = 13.$$

Thus the variation in point counts is real, even for a very small field. The points are:

$$E_1(\mathbb{F}_7) = \{O, (0, 2), (0, 5)\},$$

$$E_2(\mathbb{F}_7) = \{O, (1, 2), (1, 5), (2, 2), (2, 5), (3, 3), (3, 4), (4, 2), (4, 5), (5, 3), (5, 4), (6, 3), (6, 4)\}.$$

 **Exercise 1.23.** Use your answer to Exercise 1.3 to compute a bound for $\#E(\mathbb{F}_q)$ better than the naive bound $\#E(\mathbb{F}_q) \leq 2q + 1$.

 **Exercise 1.24.** Enumerate the curves $y^2 = x^3 + ax + b$ over $\mathbb{F}_7$ with nonzero discriminant. Verify that the curves in Example 1.22 attain the smallest and largest possible point counts.

 **Exercise 1.25.** For $p = 5, 7, 11$, use SageMath to enumerate all pairs (a, b) with $4a^3 + 27b^2 \neq 0$ and record the possible values of $\#E(\mathbb{F}_p)$. Compare your data with Hasse's interval.

 **Exercise 1.26.** For several primes p , compute $\lfloor p + 1 + 2\sqrt{p} \rfloor$ and enumerate all nonsingular curves $y^2 = x^3 + ax + b$ over $\mathbb{F}_p$. Let $M(p)$ be the number of pairs (a, b) whose curve has this maximal permitted number of points. Record the values of $M(p)$ and look for a pattern.

1.5 Practice problems

The following problems collect the operations used throughout the lecture. Work the first three by hand before checking any computations with SageMath.

 **Exercise 1.27.** Over $\mathbb{F}_{11}$, consider

$$E: y^2 = x^3 + 2x + 7.$$

Compute the discriminant and verify that E is nonsingular. Make a table of the quadratic residues in $\mathbb{F}_{11}$, then use it to enumerate $E(\mathbb{F}_{11})$.

 **Exercise 1.28.** Use your point count for $E/\mathbb{F}_{11}$ to check Hasse's bound. Determine the group structure of $E(\mathbb{F}_{11})$.

These are the same operations implemented by an elliptic-curve cryptographic library. The only difference in practice is the size of the field and the subgroup: production parameters make direct enumeration and trial search infeasible.

Lecture 2: The elliptic-curve discrete logarithm problem

The group law turns an elliptic curve into a setting for public-key cryptography. In this lecture, we will study the theoretical foundations of the elliptic-curve discrete logarithm problem (ECDLP).

2.1 Public-key cryptography

Public-key cryptography lets people who have never met establish secure communication over a public channel. The channel might be the Internet, a wireless network, or any other medium on which an adversary can read the messages. We will call the two people who want to communicate Alice and Bob, and call an adversary Eve. A cryptographic protocol specifies what Alice and Bob send, what they keep secret, and what Eve is allowed to see.

The basic aim is to turn a secret key into something useful. A secret **key** is a short piece of information used by a cryptographic algorithm. For example, a symmetric encryption algorithm uses the *same* secret key to encrypt and decrypt:

$$\text{plaintext} \xrightarrow{\text{encrypt with } K} \text{ciphertext} \xrightarrow{\text{decrypt with } K} \text{plaintext}.$$

Symmetric encryption is fast and is what normally protects the contents of a long message. Its difficulty is key distribution: how can Alice and Bob obtain the common secret key K in the first place if Eve can observe their communication?

Public-key cryptography addresses this problem by giving each participant a pair of related keys:

$$\text{public key} \quad \text{and} \quad \text{private key}.$$

The public key may be published or sent over the public channel. The private key must be sampled randomly and kept only by its owner. The two keys are constructed so that a public key can be computed efficiently from its private key, while recovering the private key from the public key is believed to be computationally infeasible. Security does not rely on hiding the algorithm: the curve, the protocol, and all public parameters are assumed to be known to Eve.

Public-key techniques have two common roles. First, **key agreement** allows Alice and Bob to derive a common symmetric key; Diffie–Hellman is the example studied below. Second, **digital signatures** allow a sender to prove possession of a private key, so that anyone with the corresponding public key can verify the sender’s signature. In practice, a protocol often uses public-key cryptography to authenticate participants and agree on a temporary symmetric key, then uses symmetric encryption to protect the data.

For elliptic-curve cryptography, the relevant one-way-looking operation is *scalar multiplication*. Public parameters include an elliptic curve $E/\mathbb{F}_q$ and a publicly known point P .

Alice chooses a secret integer a (her private key) and computes

$$A = [a]P.$$

She may publish A as her public key. Repeatedly adding P to itself (using the fast double-and-add algorithm) computes $[a]P$ efficiently. The reverse task—given P and A , recover a —is the elliptic-curve discrete logarithm problem. The remainder of this lecture makes this statement precise and explains how it leads to Diffie–Hellman key agreement.

Warning 2.1. Public information is not necessarily harmless information. A public key is safe to reveal only because the associated mathematical problem is hard for the chosen parameters. Tiny examples are excellent for learning the protocols, but their private keys can be found by simply trying all possibilities. Moreover, mathematical hardness alone does not provide every security property: key agreement must be authenticated to prevent an active attacker from impersonating a participant.

2.2 Further structure of the points on elliptic curves

Before we start looking at the discrete logarithm problem, we need to understand the structure of the group of points on an elliptic curve over a finite field. Because $E(\mathbb{F}_q)$ is a finite abelian group, it has a particularly simple form:

Theorem 2.2. *For an elliptic curve $E/\mathbb{F}_q$, there are positive integers N_1, N_2 with $N_2 \mid N_1$ and $N_2 \mid (q - 1)$ such that*

$$E(\mathbb{F}_q) \simeq \mathbb{Z}/N_1\mathbb{Z} \times \mathbb{Z}/N_2\mathbb{Z}.$$

For an elliptic curve E/k and any positive integer N , the N -torsion subgroup is

$$E[N] = \{P \in E(\bar{k}) : [N]P = O\}.$$

If $\text{char}(k)$ does not divide N , then

$$E[N] \simeq \mathbb{Z}/N\mathbb{Z} \times \mathbb{Z}/N\mathbb{Z}.$$

In characteristic p , the p -power torsion is more subtle. For $n \geq 1$, over an algebraic closure, as we will see later that $E[p^n]$ is trivial when E is *supersingular* and is isomorphic to $\mathbb{Z}/p^n\mathbb{Z}$ when E is *ordinary*.

 **Exercise 2.3.** Using Sage, compute the point sets and determine the group structures of the following curves over $\mathbb{F}_{23}$:

$$y^2 = x^3 + x + 1, \quad y^2 = x^3 - x, \quad y^2 = x^3 + 5x + 15.$$

 **Exercise 2.4.** Let $p > 3$, and let

$$E : y^2 = x^3 + ax + b, \quad \tilde{E} : y^2 = x^3 + ax - b$$

be elliptic curves over $\mathbb{F}_p$. Show that if $p \equiv 1 \pmod{4}$, then $\#E(\mathbb{F}_p) = \#\tilde{E}(\mathbb{F}_p)$; if $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$, show that $\#E(\mathbb{F}_p) + \#\tilde{E}(\mathbb{F}_p) = 2p + 2$. Hint: determine when -1 is a square in $\mathbb{F}_p$.

2.3 The discrete logarithm problem

Now we are ready to study the discrete logarithm problem, a problem that is easy to state, but believed to be hard to solve. The problem is defined in any finite group, but we will focus on the case of elliptic curves over finite fields.

Problem 2.5 (Elliptic-curve discrete logarithm problem, ECDLP). Given an elliptic curve E over a finite field $\mathbb{F}_q$, a point $P \in E(\mathbb{F}_q)$ of prime order n , and a point $Q \in \langle P \rangle$, find the unique $d \in \{0, \dots, n-1\}$ such that

$$Q = [d]P.$$

The integer d is called the **discrete logarithm** of Q to the base P .

Example 2.6. On the curve of Example 1.14, $P = (0, 1)$ has order 5 and $[3]P = (2, 2)$. Hence the discrete logarithm of $(2, 2)$ to the base P is 3. This tiny example is deliberately insecure: trying all five possibilities is easy.

The best general classical attacks, such as Pollard rho, use roughly $\sqrt{n}$ group operations and little memory. Therefore a subgroup of order about 2^{256} gives an approximately 128-bit classical security target. Special curves or poorly chosen parameters can be weaker, so practical ECC uses standardized, audited curves and algorithms.

 **Exercise 2.7.** Let P have order n . Show that $[a]P = [b]P$ if and only if $a \equiv b \pmod{n}$. Why does this prove uniqueness in the ECDLP definition?

2.4 What is assumed to be hard?

The decomputational Diffie–Hellman problem (CDH) in the subgroup $\langle P \rangle$ is: given

$$A = [a]P \quad \text{and} \quad B = [b]P,$$

compute $[ab]P$. The security of unauthenticated ECDH against a passive eavesdropper is modeled by the difficulty of this problem.

An algorithm for ECDLP solves CDH: recover a from (P, A) and then compute $[a]B$. The converse implication is not known in complete generality, so the two assumptions should not be identified. For well-chosen elliptic-curve groups, no general classical algorithm is known that is asymptotically faster than generic square-root search.

2.5 Diffie–Hellman key agreement

Diffie–Hellman is a *key-agreement* protocol, not an encryption protocol. It lets two parties derive the same shared secret over a public channel in the chosen subgroup.

1. Alice and Bob agree on public parameters $(E, \mathbb{F}_q, P, n)$, where P has prime order n .
2. Alice samples $a \in \{1, \dots, n-1\}$ uniformly and sends $A = [a]P$.
3. Bob samples $b \in \{1, \dots, n-1\}$ uniformly and sends $B = [b]P$.
4. Alice computes $S_A = [a]B$ and Bob computes $S_B = [b]A$.

Both obtain the same point

$$S_A = [a]([b]P) = [ab]P = [b]([a]P) = S_B.$$

The protocol uses a key-derivation function (KDF) on an agreed encoding of S_A , together with the public transcript, to obtain symmetric key material; the point P is not used directly as an encryption key.

Example 2.8 (A toy ECDH exchange). On the curve in Example 1.14, take the generator $P = (0, 1)$ of order 5. If Alice chooses $a = 2$ and Bob chooses $b = 3$, then

$$A = [2]P = (2, 5), \quad B = [3]P = (2, 2).$$

Alice computes $[2]B = [6]P = P$, while Bob computes $[3]A = [6]P = P$. Thus they obtain the same shared point. The calculation also makes clear why the scalars are read modulo 5: here $6 \equiv 1 \pmod{5}$.

One curve that is widely used is the one recommended by the Internet Research Task Force (IRTF) given by the following equation over $\mathbb{F}_p$ with $p = 2^{255} - 19$:

$$E : y^2 = x^3 + 486662x^2 + x.$$

The base point recommended for use has coordinates $x = 9$ and $y =$

$$14781619447589544791020593568409986887264606134616475288964881837755586237401.$$

The order of this point is a prime number

$$n = 2^{252} + 27742317777372353535851937790883648493.$$

Moreover, NIST, the US National Institute of Standards and Technology, has a list of 15 elliptic curves that are recommended for use in cryptography. The curves are defined over prime fields $\mathbb{F}_p$ and binary fields $\mathbb{F}_{2^m}$, and have been chosen to have a prime number of points or a small cofactor.

Warning 2.9. Unauthenticated Diffie–Hellman does *not* authenticate Alice or Bob. An active attacker can replace A and B and mount a man-in-the-middle attack. Real protocols authenticate the exchange, for example with signatures, certificates, or a pre-shared authentication mechanism. Implementations must also validate received public points and handle cofactors according to the chosen curve protocol.

 **Exercise 2.10.** Suppose an implementation accepts the point $B = O$ as Bob’s public message. What shared point does Alice compute, regardless of her secret scalar a ? Explain why checking subgroup membership alone does not rule out this case, and state an additional check the implementation should make.

 **Exercise 2.11.** In the subgroup generated by the point P of Example 1.14, let Alice choose $a = 2$ and Bob choose $b = 3$. Compute A , B , and the shared point.

 **Exercise 2.12** (A tiny discrete-log table). On the curve and with the generator $P = (0, 1)$ from Example 1.14, write down the table

$$O, P, [2]P, [3]P, [4]P.$$

Use it to find the discrete logarithm of each nonidentity point to the base P . Which part of this method becomes infeasible when the subgroup order is about 2^{256} ?

 **Exercise 2.13** (Why square-root attacks matter). Suppose that a generic discrete-logarithm attack requires approximately $\sqrt{n}$ group operations in a subgroup of prime order n .

1. Estimate the work factor when n is about 2^{256} .
2. If an attacker can carry out 2^{40} group operations per second, estimate, in years, how long 2^{128} operations would take.
3. Explain why this estimate motivates describing such a subgroup as offering roughly 128 bits of classical security.

 **Exercise 2.14** (A man-in-the-middle exchange). Alice sends $A = [a]P$ and Bob sends $B = [b]P$, but an active adversary Eve replaces Alice's message by $A' = [e_A]P$ and Bob's message by $B' = [e_B]P$, for scalars chosen by Eve.

1. Determine the point computed by Alice and the point computed by Bob.
2. Determine the two points Eve can compute from A , B , e_A , and e_B .
3. Explain how Eve can use these two shared points to read and alter messages if Alice and Bob do not authenticate the exchange.

 **Exercise 2.15** (Transporting a discrete logarithm). Let $\varphi : E \rightarrow E'$ be a group homomorphism, and suppose that P has prime order n and that $\varphi(P)$ also has order n . If $Q = [d]P$, prove that

$$\varphi(Q) = [d]\varphi(P).$$

Show that a solution to the discrete logarithm problem for $(\varphi(P), \varphi(Q))$ recovers d modulo n . Why is the assumption on the order of $\varphi(P)$ essential?

Bibliography

- [AM26] Sarah Arpin and ChloeE Martindale. Arizona Winter School (paws) lectures, 2026. swc-math.github.io. ↑[ii](#).
- [HPS14] Jeffrey Hoffstein, Jill Pipher, and Joseph H. Silverman. *An introduction to mathematical cryptography*. Undergraduate Texts in Mathematics. Springer, New York, second edition, 2014. ↑[ii](#).
- [Kun26] Sabrina Kunzweiler. Preliminary Arizona Winter School (paws) lectures, 2026. swc-math.github.io. ↑[ii](#).
- [Sil09] Joseph H. Silverman. *The arithmetic of elliptic curves*, volume 106 of *Graduate Texts in Mathematics*. Springer, Dordrecht, second edition, 2009. ↑[ii](#), [6](#), [7](#).
- [Zag87] Don Zagier. Large integral points on elliptic curves. *Math. Comp.*, 48(177):425–436, 1987. ↑[4](#).